TCS made its debut at the National Stock Exchange (NSE) and the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE). It was the largest IPO in India by a private sector firm until then. To make the offering attractive to the retail investors, each share was priced at Rs 850. The company was listed on 25 August. It was a resounding success and was oversubscribed by 7.7 times. It got listed at Rs 1,199 on NSE. The listing made it India's third-most valuable company. It brought the company $1.2 billion.

The share pricing was also determined by Ratan. It was carefully fixed to give investors an 'attractive upside' as a 'token of our gratitude to their overwhelming response to the issue', he said. If he'd had the choice, he would have allocated all the shares to investors. But according to SEBI rules, '60 per cent had to be allocated to institutional investors', 15 per cent to non-institutional investors and only the remaining 25 per cent could be allocated to retail investors. Ratan was unhappy with this provision and was quoted as telling Ramadorai: 'You know it should be given to the people, they have backed us.'

The IPO also had a very fair share for the employees. According to SEBI's extant rules, TCS set apart 5.5 million shares for purchase by its active employees. The 'yardstick used for the allocation of shares was a combination of experience and performance'. The distribution formula was worked out by Ramadorai and Ratan. The support staff was made eligible for the shares as well.

The decision to take TCS public was one of the most important highlights of Ratan's stewardship as chairman, Tata Sons, and perhaps a telling contribution of his to TCS. 'It was a masterpiece of a decision,' recalls Ishaat Hussain. Chandrasekaran airs the same opinion. Though 'people do not talk about it', it was Ratan's 'singular' achievement, and it made all the difference to the company, he said. 'I cannot tell you how much difference it has made … If you would not have taken TCS public, it would not have been the company it is today.' It reaped enormous benefits.

Before TCS went public, 'we did not understand competition', Chandrasekaran explains. 'We did not know the financial market … Some of the decisions we had taken, we would not have taken, without having gone public … When we went public, we got a lot of analysis and criticism.' Citing an instance, he says that around 22 per cent of the company's revenues came from General Electric (GE) at the time and this high client concentration came in for sharp criticism. Consequently, a